Vayaitzei 5785

There is a fascinating discussion brought down in the wonderful Torah journal קול התורה, which comes out twice a year from England. In this week's Parsha, ויצא, it delves into an intriguing problem regarding the tremendous נבואה to which אבינו יעקב was זוכה, the vision of the סֻלָּם מֻצָּב אַרְצָה. In this נבואה, he saw מלאכים and הקדוש ברוך הוא. Upon experiencing this, he exclaimed (28:16): אָכֵן יֵשׁ ה' בַּמָּקוֹם הַזֶּה and then further stated (28:17): וַיִּירָא וַיֹּאמֶר מַה נּוֹרָא הַמָּקוֹם הַזֶּה אֵין זֶה כִּי אִם בֵּית אֱלֹקִים - This is the place of the בית המקדש - not only for now, but for all דורות. It is a tremendously holy place.

The מפרשים raise an interesting question, brought down from a rebbi in Bnei Brak named R' Aaron Goodman. The phrasing in the פסוק is peculiar: אֵין זֶה כִּי אִם בֵּית אֱלֹקִים. If you or I were speaking, we would say מַה נּוֹרָא הַמָּקוֹם הַזֶּה, כִּי זֶה בֵּית אֱלֹקִים. What is the תורה teaching us with this specific phrasing?

The חתם סופר addresses this in שו"ת חתם סופר, יורה דעה סימן רל"ג, in the name of his rebbi, R' Nosson Adler. He explains, based on מדרשים, a critical הלכה relevant to us. The מדרש states that in ארץ ישראל, עבודה זרה was so rampant that every high place - every גִּבְעָה נשואה or הר גבוה - was associated with עבודה זרה. The question then arises: how could הקדוש ברוך הוא choose a place that had עבודה זרה to house the בית המקדש? Wouldn't the טומאה from the עבודה זרה render the location unfit?

R' Nosson Adler answers with another מדרש, which explains that when אברהם אבינו came for the עקדה and saw the מקום המקדש from afar, as we know (22:4) וַיַּרְא אֶת הַמָּקוֹם מֵרָחֹק. At that time, the מקום המקדש was a valley, not a mountain. אברהם אבינו exclaimed that it was not fitting for הקדוש ברוך הוא's שכינה to dwell in a valley, and at that very moment, a miraculous event occurred: the valley rose and became a mountain. This מדרש asserts that because the mountain did not exist before that moment, it had never been associated with עבודה זרה.

Moreover, אברהם אבינו was מקדש the mountain and was קונה it; it was given to him. Once it belonged to אברהם, it could no longer be subjected to עבודה זרה. The מדרש emphasizes that even if others placed getchkas on it, they had no רשות because the mountain belonged to אברהם, and as we know, a person cannot אסור דבר שאינו שלו. Thus, when יעקב אבינו said אֵין זֶה כִּי אִם בֵּית אֱלֹקִים, he was emphasizing that this place was inherently holy, never tainted by עבודה זרה, and therefore fit for הקדוש ברוך הוא's שכינה to dwell.

This מדרש and its message are powerful for us in many ways. It teaches us that through our words and actions, we too can cause tremendous spiritual effects in both עולם הזה and עולם הבא. While we cannot compare ourselves to the אבות הקדושים, who had unparalleled spiritual capabilities, we must not underestimate our potential.

May we use our abilities to perform מצוות and מעשים טובים to be מזכה ourselves and all of כלל ישראל, and bezras Hashem, further the גאולה במהרה בימינו אמן!

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